

DESIRE — Caffeine Pouch Category Research Dossier

2026-09-18 · @Someone

0. Scope, method, and what this document can and cannot prove

Subject: the nicotine-free caffeine / energy pouch category, researched for DESIRE (80 mg caffeine, 80 mg L-theanine, 40 mg L-tyrosine, vitamin B6, vitamin B12; 15 pouches per tin; Cool Mint, Watermelon Ice, Mixed Berry; DTC Shopify; premium positioning). Research conducted 18 September 2026, prioritising sources from the last 24 months.

0.1 Evidence standard

Every factual statement carries **[VERIFIED]** (traced to a primary or reputable source, linked) or **[MARKET BELIEF]** (something buyers widely believe, recorded because it drives purchase behaviour, not because it is true). Several market beliefs below are factually wrong. They are still worth more to a copywriter than the correct fact, because copy has to start where the reader already is.

Every quote is verbatim, with original spelling and typos preserved, plus platform, date and link. Nothing here is invented. Where the brief asked for evidence that does not exist in retrievable public sources, the section is marked **NO EVIDENCE FOUND** and left empty rather than padded.

0.2 Four findings about the evidence itself — read before Section 1

These are not caveats. Two of them are directly monetisable.

Finding A — the category's search results are almost entirely brand-owned.
[VERIFIED]

Searching "best caffeine pouches 2026" returns, in the top ten: six separate listicles from [nectr.energy](#), plus [cream.energy](#), [takeroon.com](#), [zarpouch.com](#) and [cyclonepods.com](#). Every one is a competing pouch brand publishing an "objective" ranking in which it places itself first. Nectr names itself #1 in four different articles under four different criteria. Roon's "best nootropics Reddit recommends" piece concludes: *"That's exactly what Roon built."*

Cyclone is the only one that states the conflict: *"We make Cyclone Focus Pouches, a competing product, so we are stating our bias upfront."*

Why this matters commercially: there is no trusted third-party voice in this category. A buyer researching "which caffeine pouch should I buy" is reading five sales pages disguised as reviews with no way to tell. That is a trust vacuum, and it is the largest unexploited opening in the category (Section 6.4).

Finding B — much of the rest is AI-generated spam. [VERIFIED]

Across multiple queries, a large share of results resolved to a single content farm (`kjhave3.digital.vic.edu`) publishing dozens of near-identical machine-written articles containing outright fabrications — including that Zyn sells coffee-flavoured caffeine pouches, and that *"Swedish Match was one of the first companies to introduce caffeine pouches to the market, with brands like Zyn and On!"* That is false. This content is indexed, reachable by ordinary buyers, and actively reinforces the nicotine/caffeine confusion documented in Section 4.

Finding C — retail has already classified this product as nicotine replacement. [VERIFIED]

Walmart Business files Grinds Energy Pouches under this breadcrumb: *Healthcare* → *Patient Care* → *Over The Counter* → **Smoking Cessation** → *Lozenge* ([source](#)). Not supplements. Not energy. Not sports nutrition. The largest retailer in the world has decided what this category is for, and the customer reviews on that same page agree with it. For positioning purposes this is the most important single fact in this document.

Finding D — two real limits on the evidence below.

- 1. Reddit was not retrievable at scale through the available search index.** Repeated queries across subreddit, topic and phrase formulations returned brand listicles and spam farms rather than Reddit permalinks. The brief ranked Reddit as the top-priority source; that source is largely absent here. Quotes below come instead from retailer review widgets (Walmart, Amazon, brand-site syndication), forums (Steam, KillTheCan, HealthUnlocked, Slickdeals, AnandTech) and news reporting. **Sections requiring 10-15 quotes per segment fall short of the brief's minimum and are marked as such rather than padded.**
- 2. Many retrievable pouch reviews are platform-labelled "Incentivized Review"** — the reviewer received the product free or discounted. On the Grinds White Peach page, the majority of recent five-star reviews carry that tag ([source](#)). Incentivised reviews are still real customer language and usable as voice-of-customer, but are not reliable evidence of spontaneous satisfaction. Each is flagged `[INCENTIVISED]` below.

0.3 How to use this

Sections 1–4 are raw material: what people say and believe. Sections 5–6 are competitive fact. Section 7 is the villain. Section 8 is curiosity fuel. **Section 9 is the constraint that governs all of it** — several of the most persuasive angles in this category are not legally usable in the EU or UK, and one is not usable anywhere without substantiation DESIRE does not currently hold. Read Section 9 before writing a single headline. Section 10 is the working copy kit.

1. Buyer psychology, by segment

Quote-count status against the brief: the brief asked for 10+ verbatim quotes per segment. Retrieved: gym-goers 6, students 0, gamers 0, professionals/drivers 6, nicotine crossover 9 (Section 4 holds those). **Students and gamers returned NO USABLE VERBATIM EVIDENCE** through the available index. Those two segments are written as open questions, not as analysis dressed up as findings. See Section 10.H.

1.1 Gym-goers and lifters

Who they are. No reliable demographic dataset for pouch-buying lifters was retrievable. What is verifiable is the product they are leaving: pre-workout powders sit at 150–350 mg caffeine per serving. Legion Pulse is 350 mg, Transparent Labs BULK Black 300 mg, C4 Original 150 mg ([source](#)). [VERIFIED]

The failure moments, in their words.

"I tried the skittles flavour C4 this morning and I literally felt like I had ants biting me all over my body for hours, and people are telling me that's normal?!" — Violent Rainbow, Steam Forums, 24 Apr 2024 ([source](#)) [gym]

"You know it didn't even taste like skittles, it tasted good like candy but not skittles. Honestly I was disappointed, that one can cost me \$8 but I like to try new things, I just wasn't ready for the horrible. horrible full body fire ant biting itchiness." — Violent Rainbow, Steam Forums, 24 Apr 2024 ([source](#)) [gym]

"I mean I drank one can, but it was a whole can and it was kinda all at once so... maybe? I mean there's no instructions, I didn't even know what it is I just thought it was a regular energy drink! They should put warnings on those things! Big warnings!" — Violent Rainbow, Steam Forums, 24 Apr 2024 ([source](#)) [gym] — **dose uncertainty in the customer's own words**

"Hey so about a year ago I was at the gym and decided I really wanted to get a feel for a pump so I bought this Pre-Workout C4 300mg Caffeine and I ended up in the hospital with heart palpitations and really bad high blood pressure. It took me a while to recover from it." — victorgomez27, HealthUnlocked Anxiety & Depression Support ([source](#)) [gym]

"I have played football through college and taken all of those pre workouts they are very dangerous a lot end up as being amphetamine analogs." — reply in the same thread ([source](#)) [gym] — [MARKET BELIEF], and a partly true one (see Section 7.2)

"I also dropped a pretty penny trying them myself, only to find out that about 95% of them give me the jitters and for many uncomfortable hours after I've finished working out. Plus, I wasn't focused like some products claim and I made quite a few trips to the bathroom (gross I know, but it's the truth)." — Nichole, Walmart verified purchase, 21 Nov 2023 ([source](#)) [gym]

The in-group attitude to watch. The most revealing line in the pre-workout threads is the dismissal, not the complaint:

"Don't buy pre-workouts... They're a waste of money just drink coffee." — Makete Kate, Steam Forums, 24 Apr 2024 ([source](#)) [gym]

This is the position DESIRE has to beat, and it is not "pre-workout is bad." It is **"the whole supplement category is a markup on caffeine, and coffee is the honest version."** Anything that reads as another flavoured scoop with a proprietary blend loses to that line. The counter is not more benefits — it is *disclosed dose*.

How they feel about dependence. NO DIRECT EVIDENCE FOUND for lifters specifically. The adjacent evidence — the Steam and HealthUnlocked threads — shows dependence is not the anxiety; **loss of control over the dose is**. Every one of the quotes above is about

not knowing what they took, not about taking it regularly. That is a meaningful distinction for copy: this segment is not looking to quit caffeine, and messaging that implies they should will miss.

Core belief in their voice: *"I need the stimulant, I just don't want to feel insane for three hours. I've been sold enough scoops. Tell me the number and let me decide."*

1.2 Students

NO EVIDENCE FOUND. No verbatim student quotes about caffeine, energy products or pouches were retrievable through the available search index. No demographic data on student caffeine-pouch use was retrievable either. This segment is written nowhere in this document on the basis of assumption. Treat it as the single biggest research gap and the first thing to survey (Section 10.H).

One adjacent verified fact that bears on it: **EFSA has ruled that for adolescents aged 10–18, safe daily caffeine intake is 3 mg per kg of bodyweight** ([source](#)). [VERIFIED] For a 60 kg 17-year-old that is 180 mg — slightly over two DESIRE pouches. Some of the "student" market is under 18. See Section 9 on age restrictions before writing any campus-facing copy.

1.3 Gamers and esports

NO EVIDENCE FOUND. No verbatim gamer quotes about caffeine pouches or energy products were retrievable. The one gaming-platform thread that did surface (Steam) is about pre-workout and is filed under gym above, because the speaker is describing a gym session.

1.4 Busy professionals, shift workers and drivers

Who they are. The most documented sub-segment is long-haul drivers, and their situation is structural rather than preferential: they are alone, restricted from phone use, often restricted in what they can play, and legally required to keep moving. [VERIFIED — [industry account](#), 2018, older than the 24-month window]

In their words (note: these two threads are from 2010 and are labelled accordingly — they describe attitudes, not a current market):

"I once knew a guy that kept 2 6-packs of Pepsi in his car - per day! He was addicted to caffeine, and needed it just to function at a near normal level. In short, he was a drug addict. It is not good to be dependent on sugar and caffeine to stay awake." — Moosetek13, TheTruckersReport, 21 Nov 2010 ([source](#)) [drivers] [2010 — OLD]

"And I'll take a NoDoz every few hours to keep me a bit more alert. But it is easy to overdo it, if you ignore the warning signs." — Moosetek13, same thread ([source](#)) [drivers] [2010 — OLD]

"I think with the way the laws are it forces drivers to drive tired so they drink that stuff to get thru the day. Or they get into a position to where they have to run at night. I know some people who can't sleep at all if it daylight out." — TheTruckersReport, 29 Sep 2010 ([source](#)) [drivers] [2010 — OLD]

"Typically, anything that jacks you up for a while makes you pay for it later. And I finally found a gig where I'm not going into work at 5PM and wrestling to get to sleep after the sun comes up. Most of us with common sense are wary of over the counter supplements, ie: energy or sexual miracle potions." — nhroadhog01, TheTruckersReport, 29 Sep 2010 ([source](#)) [drivers] [2010 — OLD]

"I've been off caffeine for several years and will be new to otr. Are there any drivers not taking caffeine (coffee, sodas, caffeinated energy drinks) out there? What do you use for a pick-me-up when needed?" — sherd, TheTruckersReport ([source](#)) [drivers] [2010 — OLD]

"Bless ur heart...I wish I could say the same but I can't stop drinking sodas....sorry I couldn't be any help to ya." — reply in the same thread ([source](#)) [drivers] [2010 — OLD]

One current, dated professional-use quote, from a caffeine pouch buyer:

"Gives me the extra boost at the end of the day to make it through work. The flavor starts good but after a short while it tends to get bitter, but it works." — Kevin, Walmart verified purchase, 8 May 2026 ([source](#)) [professionals] [INCENTIVISED]

How they feel about dependence. This is the segment where dependence is moralised, and it is moralised *harshly and by peers*, not by outsiders. "He was a drug addict." "Most of us with common sense are wary of over the counter supplements." The self-image at stake is competence and self-discipline: a professional who *needs* something is a professional who can't do the job.

Copy implication, and it is the opposite of the obvious one: do not sell this segment "energy." Energy implies deficiency. Sell **control** — a known dose, taken deliberately, instead of a 32 oz drink of unknown strength consumed because it was what the truck stop had. Frame it as the disciplined choice, not the rescue.

Core belief in their voice: *"Needing it is weakness, but the schedule doesn't care what I need. I'd rather take something measured than drink a gallon of sugar and pretend that's different."*

1.5 Current and former nicotine pouch users

This segment's evidence, quotes and analysis are in **Section 4**, which the brief designated a priority investigation. It is the strongest-evidenced segment in this document and the only one where retrievable customers are saying, unprompted and in current dated reviews, exactly why they bought a caffeine pouch.

2. Existing solutions: what they use, love, and hate

The single most useful fact in this section: a standard 8.4 oz Red Bull contains **80 mg of caffeine** ([source](#)). [VERIFIED] DESIRE is 80 mg. That is an exact, checkable, one-line equivalence — *one pouch, one Red Bull, no can* — and it is the clearest dose anchor available to this brand in any market. Use it.

Quote-count status: the brief asked for 5+ verbatim quotes per solution across ten solutions. Retrieved quotes cluster heavily on pre-workout and pouches; coffee, tea, gels, gum and shots returned little or nothing usable. Marked per solution below.

2.1 Dose and cost reference table [VERIFIED]

Solution	Typical caffeine dose	Typical cost per serving	Time to consume	Top complaints in customer language
Brewed coffee (8 oz)	80–100 mg	≈\$0.30 home / \$3–6 cafe	5–15 min + brew time	NO QUOTES RETRIEVED
Red Bull (8.4 oz)	80 mg	≈\$2.50–3.50	5–10 min	"sugar", "crash" (see 2.3)
Monster (16 oz)	160 mg, 54 g sugar	≈\$2.50–3.50	15–30 min	sugar load, can size, has to be finished
Celsius Heat / Bang / Rockstar Xduration (16 oz)	300 mg	≈\$2.50–3.50	15–30 min	75% of EFSA's <i>daily</i> ceiling in one can
5-Hour Energy (2 oz)	200 mg	≈\$3–4	<1 min	NO QUOTES RETRIEVED
Pre-workout (C4 Original)	150 mg	≈\$1–1.50	5 min mix + 20–30 min wait	itching, jitters, gut, dose opacity
Pre-workout (Transparent Labs BULK Black)	300 mg	≈\$1.50–2	as above	as above
Pre-workout (Legion Pulse)	350 mg	≈\$1.50–2	as above	as above
Caffeine pills (NoDoz)	100–200 mg	≈\$0.15–0.30	<1 min	"easy to overdo it"
Grinds coffee pouches	20–25 mg (2x line 50 mg)	\$0.24–0.33	30–60 min	dose inconsistency, grounds escaping
Grinds energy pouches	80 mg	≈\$0.44–1.33	30–60 min	bitterness, flavour turn

Solution	Typical caffeine dose	Typical cost per serving	Time to consume	Top complaints in customer language
DESIRE	80 mg + 80 mg L-theanine + 40 mg L-tyrosine + B6 + B12	TBD — see §5.4	<1 min to place	TBD

Sources: [energy drink caffeine list](#), [pre-workout doses](#), [Grinds pricing](#), [Grinds Amazon 80 mg listing](#).

2.2 Pre-workout powders — the richest vein of hatred in the category

What they like. The ritual and the ramp. Nobody in the retrieved evidence praises the ingredients; they praise the *absence* of side effects, which is telling:

"You get natural boost of energy with no crash out and definitely no itching." — Yaritza, Walmart verified purchase, 21 Sep 2025 ([source](#))

"Unlike other products I've tried, it doesn't give me the jitters, but it provides just the right amount of energy to power through my workouts. I feel focused and energized without any crash afterward." — Walmart-syndicated review from legionathletics.com ([source](#))

Read that carefully. In this category, the *positive* reviews are written as relief from the negative. The benefit customers articulate is "it didn't do the bad thing." That is the emotional shape DESIRE's copy should take, and it is unusual — most supplement copy sells addition; this market buys subtraction.

What they hate. Four distinct frictions, all quoted in §1.1: **beta-alanine itching, jitters lasting hours after the session, gut urgency**, and **no idea what's in it or how much**. The dose-opacity quote ("there's no instructions, I didn't even know what it is") is the one to build around, because it is the only complaint DESIRE's format structurally solves rather than merely improves.

Does the market believe it works? Partly, and cynically. "Don't buy pre-workouts... They're a waste of money just drink coffee" is the settled view of a visible minority ([Steam, 2024](#)). [MARKET BELIEF]

2.3 Energy drinks

What the market likes. NO VERBATIM QUOTES RETRIEVED. Analysis of what must be matched, from product facts rather than quotes: availability everywhere, cold, flavoured, socially normal, and — critically — **cheap per milligram**. A 300 mg Bang at \$3 is \$0.01/mg. DESIRE at 80 mg needs to justify a far higher per-mg price on grounds other than caffeine.

What the market hates. The retrievable complaint is structural rather than emotional, so the strongest available material is regulatory and clinical (Section 7), not verbatim. Two verified facts that do the work a quote would:

- **Monster Original: 160 mg caffeine and 54 g sugar per 16 oz can.** ([source](#)) [VERIFIED]
That is roughly 13 teaspoons of sugar alongside the caffeine.
- **Celsius Heat, Bang and Rockstar Xduration each deliver 300 mg in one can** ([source](#))
— **75% of EFSA's entire recommended daily ceiling**, and 50% above EFSA's single-dose guidance of 200 mg ([source](#)). [VERIFIED]

That second fact is the strongest single argument DESIRE owns against energy drinks, and it is entirely factual: **one can of several mainstream energy drinks exceeds the single-dose amount European regulators consider safe**. One DESIRE pouch is 40% of that single-dose guidance.

2.4 Coffee and espresso

NO VERBATIM QUOTES RETRIEVED. What is verifiable: 8 oz of regular coffee is 80–100 mg ([source](#)). [VERIFIED] The friction is brew time, cup, heat, breath, teeth and the fact that it cannot be taken mid-set or mid-drive. None of that is quoted here because no customer said it in a retrievable source.

The *competitive* fact worth noting: coffee is the benchmark the market defends. "Just drink coffee" is the fallback position of the cynic in every pre-workout thread. DESIRE is not competing with coffee on effect; it is competing on the situations where coffee is impossible.

2.5 Caffeine pills

"And I'll take a NoDoz every few hours to keep me a bit more alert. But it is easy to overdo it, if you ignore the warning signs." — Moosetek13, TheTruckersReport, 2010 ([source](#)) [2010 — OLD]

Pills are the closest existing product to DESIRE’s actual value proposition — known dose, no drink, portable, cheap — and the market has largely rejected them. **Why they were rejected is the most important unanswered question in this document**, because whatever killed caffeine pills (clinical feel, no ritual, no flavour, association with drugs, all-at-once absorption) is the thing DESIRE’s format has to visibly fix. NO EVIDENCE FOUND on the reason. Survey it (Section 10.H).

2.6 Caffeine gum, energy shots, energy gels, tea

NO EVIDENCE FOUND for all four. No verbatim customer language about caffeine gum, energy shots, gels or tea was retrievable from the available index. The brief asked for 5 quotes each; zero were found. The military caffeine gum history in Section 8.1 is the only substantive material available on gum, and it is historical rather than voice-of-customer.

2.7 Nicotine pouches used for stimulation

Covered in **Section 4**. This is the only "existing solution" where retrievable customers state, in dated 2026 reviews, that they switched to a caffeine pouch and why.

3. Objection mining from negative reviews

3.1 The frequency data, straight from the platform [VERIFIED]

Walmart's review widget on the Grinds New Orleans 6-can listing tags **2,168 reviews** by topic and publishes the counts ([source](#)). This is the only quantified voice-of-customer dataset found anywhere in this category. Read the ordering carefully — it is not what an energy brand would expect:

Topic tag	Mentions	Share of 2,168 reviews
Flavor	981	45.3%
Nicotine Pouches	49	2.3%
Caffeine Content	34	1.6%
Chewability	24	1.1%
Sweetness	24	1.1%
Energy Boost	21	1.0%

Topic tag	Mentions	Share of 2,168 reviews
Craving Relief	21	1.0%
Value For Money	12	0.6%
Product Quality	10	0.5%
Mouth Feel	10	0.5%
Odor	8	0.4%
Smoking Cessation	7	0.3%
Mouth And Throat Irritation	5	0.2%

Two conclusions, and both should change how DESIRE's page is built.

1. **Flavour is mentioned 29 times more often than energy.** In the largest retrievable review corpus in this category, the product is being judged almost entirely on how it tastes and how long the taste lasts. "Energy Boost" is tagged in 1% of reviews. A pouch page that leads with milligrams and mechanisms is answering a question almost nobody is asking.
2. **Combine "Nicotine Pouches" (49), "Craving Relief" (21) and "Smoking Cessation" (7) and the quit-nicotine cluster is roughly 3.5x the size of the energy cluster.** Section 4.

Rating distribution on that listing: 80.3% five-star, 1.9% one-star, 1.6% two-star. The complaint volume is genuinely low. The complaints that exist are concentrated and repetitive.

3.2 Ranked objections

Ranked by retrieved frequency and by how load-bearing each is for a purchase decision. Each tagged **product problem** (fix the item), **perception problem** (fix the positioning), or **education problem** (fix the page).

#	Objection, in the customer's words	Frequency	Segment	Type
1	<i>"The flavor starts good but after a short while it tends to get bitter, but it works."</i>	Very high — flavour is 45% of all review mentions	All	Product
2	<i>"The taste is decent at first, but it turns kind of sour. I think the taste of the caffeine starts to overcome the flavoring after a while."</i>	High	All	Product — raw caffeine bleeding through the flavour system
3	<i>"Terrible taste and texture. Almost made me throw up"</i> — the single most-helpful negative review on a 2,168-review listing	Recurring	All	Product
4	<i>"the initial flavor the first few minutes is so overpowering it gave me headache and when I went to get another the smell of the container made me nauseous"</i>	Recurring	All	Product — front-loaded flavour release
5	<i>"I had to spit out the first few minutes of liquid because it was to overpowering to swallow"</i>	Recurring	All	Education — nobody tells buyers whether to swallow

#	Objection, in the customer's words	Frequency	Segment	Type
6	<i>"Taste is good but didn't have the caffeine kick I was hoping for."</i>	High	Gym / professionals	Perception — buccal onset feels unlike a drink
7	<i>"Not sure about an energy boost but maybe."</i>	High	All	Perception / Education
8	<i>"They do have a bitterness to them but most caffeine pouches do."</i>	High — stated as category-normal	All	Product — and an opening: it is <i>not</i> inevitable
9	<i>"each pouch is filled (never had any empty/half full pouches like with other brands)"</i>	Implies widespread underfill elsewhere	All	Product — competitor QC failure
10	<i>"they have been too dry, covered with coffee grounds, popping open and leaking, %26 lacking flavor"</i>	Recurring, seller-dependent	All	Product
11	<i>"the best part is that the coffee grounds come out of the pouch within 45 seconds of putting them in your mouth... only to have the experience of Copenhagen mouth, especially in the office or when hanging out with family" (sarcastic)</i>	Recurring	Professionals	Product + Perception — the discretion promise failing in public

#	Objection, in the customer's words	Frequency	Segment	Type
12	Caffeine content varies 20–100 mg across one brand's flavours, so buyers cannot dose	Structural	Gym / professionals	Product — competitor weakness DESIRE already solves
13	<i>"I don't know if it has anything to do with the packaging change, but the pouch taste completely different... The pouch durability is what actually needed to be fixed."</i>	Recurring	All	Product
14	<i>"Curious if you.. eh hem...ugh, spit or swallow when 'dipping' one of these?"</i>	Recurring	New buyers	Education — the #1 pre-purchase unknown
15	<i>"Any actual effects or just capitalizing on the Zyn craze"</i>	Recurring	Crossover / sceptics	Perception — the legitimacy objection
16	<i>"Only wish the flavor would last longer."</i>	Recurring	All	Product
17	<i>"Would like them a tad larger" / "I'm a weirdo tho and think they are to wet"</i>	Occasional, contradictory	All	Product — no consensus; do not over-correct
18	Mouth and throat irritation	5 tagged mentions of 2,168 (0.2%)	All	Perception — feared far more than experienced

#	Objection, in the customer's words	Frequency	Segment	Type
19	<i>"For \$ almost a decent deal for 18 pouches" — faint praise on value</i>	12 tagged mentions (0.6%)	All	Perception
20	<i>"I appreciate that there are different ingredients in different flavored products. I do wish though that those ingredients would be listed on the website, especially when Taurine is one of them."</i>	Occasional but high-intent	Gym / informed	Education — and DESIRE's single best wedge

Sources for all quotes: [Grinds White Peach reviews](#), [Grinds New Orleans reviews](#), [Grinds review aggregation](#), [Slickdeals thread, 20 May 2025](#), [caffeine variance](#).

3.3 What is *not* in the complaints — and why it matters more

The brief anticipated burning gums, teeth damage, addiction fear, subscription-cancellation problems, damaged tins and shipping delays. **None of these appear at meaningful frequency in the retrieved corpus.** Mouth and throat irritation is 0.2% of tagged mentions. No retrieved review mentions fear of addiction, dental harm, or subscription traps.

That is a genuine finding, and it cuts against the instinct to reassure. **Pre-emptively answering objections nobody is raising introduces them.** A DESIRE page with a prominent "Will this hurt my gums?" section would be planting a doubt that 99.8% of the market does not currently hold. Answer it in an FAQ where the worried can find it; do not put it on the page.

The objections that are real, in order: **it stops tasting good; I couldn't tell if it worked; I didn't know whether to swallow; is this actually a nicotine thing.** Build the page around those four.

4. The nicotine pouch crossover — priority investigation

This is the best-evidenced section in the document and, on the evidence, the most valuable position available to DESIRE.

4.1 Size and trajectory [VERIFIED — SEC filings and company reporting]

Metric	Figure	Source
ZYN US shipments, 2017	4 million cans	Precedence Research
ZYN US shipments, full-year 2025	794 million cans	PMI reporting
ZYN share of US nicotine pouch market	≈70%	as above
PMI oral smoke-free shipments, Q1 2025	237 million cans, +42.0% YoY	PMI 8-K, SEC
PMI nicotine pouch volume growth, FY2025	+36%	PMI 2025 Annual Report, SEC
ZYN markets worldwide	56	as above
US nicotine pouch category retail value, 2025	>\$6 billion , at ≈\$5.50 average retail per can	Tobacco Insider
Global nicotine pouch market, 2025	\$6.9–7.05 billion	Grand View , Precedence
US teens reporting nicotine pouch use	5.4% in 2024, up from 3.0% in 2023	Northeastern, Jun 2025
Nicotine pouch sales growth, 2019–2022	+641%	as above

The format fact that matters most. PMI's own SEC filing states the conversion basis for its oral products: **"15 pouches per can in the U.S. and approximately 20 pouches per can outside the U.S."** ([PMI 8-K](#)). [VERIFIED]

DESIRE ships **15 pouches per tin**. That is not a coincidence of manufacturing — it is an exact match to the unit the American nicotine pouch user has bought 794 million times. The tin holds what their tin holds. It lasts what their tin lasts. **DESIRE's pack architecture**

is already speaking this customer's language, and the brand has probably not noticed.
Say it on the page.

4.2 They are already doing this, in dated 2026 reviews, unprompted

Every quote below is from a verified purchaser of a caffeine pouch describing why they bought it. None was solicited by a question about quitting.

"They have alot of flavor cant wait to try the other flavors im trying to quit smoking. So i have been trying all kinds of different stuff. Theys hrlp its like candy in your mouth you dont suck on candy when you smoke normally so these do help. The caffeine has been helping with the quitting of soda. yea im trying to do both at 1 time i dont want to gain weight when i stop smoking and a 6pk or more a day of soda has gotten out of hand so got to stop both." — cristina, Walmart verified purchase, **13 Mar 2026** ([source](#)) [crossover]

"Over all good product. Trying to stay away from nicotine and saw these. Taste is ok wish it came in more varieties. Just gotta get used to it." — Kimmie, Walmart verified purchase, **21 May 2026** ([source](#)) [crossover] [INCENTIVISED]

"Great alternative and love these." — Kara, Walmart verified purchase, **6 Aug 2026** ([source](#)) [crossover]

"I discovered this product and it has significantly helped in 1) keep me awake, and 2) assisting with quitting real tobacco by mimicking the 'process' of using it." — Peter C., night-shift worker, getgrinds.com via Walmart, 23 Jun 2018 ([source](#)) [crossover + shift work] — **the clearest statement of dual-job-to-be-done in the corpus**

"I bought this and zyn 3mg. This is perfect!!! ... But I have had chew in a month and I'm getting closer to quitting the zyn!" — Christopher P., 9 Sep 2019 ([source](#)) [crossover] — **caffeine pouch used as a step-down alongside Zyn, not instead of it**

"I purchase Grinds for my Brother who is a Varsity Football Coach for our local High School. He used tobacco pouches for years. He was able to quit tobacco and had used Grinds ever since. My Daughter is a smoker and drives a School Bus. She uses Grinds when driving her route. A much better replacement for tobacco and much, much cheaper" — Robin P., 17 Nov 2021 ([source](#)) [crossover + drivers]

"I was with a friend on day and noticed that he had a can of tobacco and broke his chops. He said that it's not tobacco and handed it to me. I was surprised and I threw out my tobacco and tried it, I was shocked and a hour went by and I didn't even realize that the grinds pouch was still in my mouth." — Andrew S., 17 Mar 2019 ([source](#)) [crossover]

"I've had treatment resistant depression for a long while, unable to work since 2018 and I've been hooked on Grizzly/Cope for years. The nicotine was making me even more depressed... I even spat the Grind for the first 5 days to allow the habit to draw out the nicotine withdrawal" — William H., 28 Jun 2020 ([source](#)) [crossover]

"These are not like the real thing, that being said they are great! It's as close as you will get and still very enjoyable." — William B., 21 Sep 2018 ([source](#)) [crossover] — **the honest expectation-setting line the category needs**

4.3 What they miss when they stop — and the research that explains it

The retrieved evidence says they miss **the process**, not the nicotine. "Mimicking the 'process' of using it." "It's like candy in your mouth." "I didn't even realize that the grinds pouch was still in my mouth."

There is real science behind this, and it is unusually good science for a marketing claim. **Jed Rose and colleagues at Duke University** established through denicotinized-cigarette studies that the sensorimotor ritual of tobacco use relieves craving substantially on its own, while a nicotine patch — pure chemical replacement with no ritual — barely touched the same craving. [VERIFIED as a real and well-known research line; **the specific effect sizes were not independently verified here** and the summary reaching this document came via a competitor's blog ([Roön](#)), which is not an acceptable source for a claim DESIRE publishes. **Pull the original Rose papers before citing this.**]

What this supports, if verified: **the habit and the drug are two separate systems, and a nicotine-free pouch addresses one of them honestly.** That is a genuine unique mechanism, it is scientifically real, and no caffeine pouch brand in the retrieved competitive set is building its primary positioning on it.

4.4 How the crossover is discussed — including the sceptics

Not everyone treats this as legitimate. The cynical read, verbatim:

"Anyone tried this? Curious if you.. eh hem...ugh, spit or swallow when 'dipping' one of these? Any actual effects or just capitalizing on the Zyn craze" — Illsway, Slickdeals, **20 May 2025** ([source](#)) [crossover/sceptic]

That one comment contains **both** of the category's core objections in nineteen words: *do I swallow this*, and *is this a real product or a bandwagon*. Answer both above the fold.

4.5 Nicotine/caffeine confusion — how hard "nicotine free" has to work

Very hard. Evidence:

- **Walmart files caffeine pouches under Smoking Cessation.** [VERIFIED — [breadcrumb](#)]
- **Walmart's own review widget tags "Nicotine Pouches" as the second-most-frequent topic** across 2,168 reviews of a product containing no nicotine ([source](#)). [VERIFIED]
- **Indexed AI-generated content actively teaches buyers that Zyn makes caffeine pouches** and that Swedish Match invented the category (§0.2 Finding B). Both false. [VERIFIED as published; the claims themselves are false]
- Grinds' own listing title reads "Nicotine-Free" before the flavour name ([Walmart](#)) — the incumbent has concluded the disclaimer must come first.

Implication for packaging and page: "Nicotine free" is not a reassurance to place in the footer. It is a **category-defining statement that must appear on the tin face, in the product title, in the ad's first three words, and in the Amazon/Walmart listing name.**

The market's default assumption is that a pouch contains nicotine, and two of the largest information sources a buyer will encounter — Walmart's taxonomy and Google's top results — are both reinforcing that assumption right now.

4.6 The strategic read

DESIRE is selling a product whose largest, best-evidenced, fastest-growing and least-contested demand pool is **people leaving nicotine who want to keep the tin**. The evidence for this is stronger than the evidence for any of the five named target segments except possibly professionals.

This does not mean abandoning gym, student and gamer positioning. It means the **crossover is the beachhead**, and the athletic/focus positioning is the expansion. The reverse order — leading with performance and treating quit-nicotine as a footnote — is what every competitor in Section 6 is currently doing, and it is why none of them has taken the position.

One serious constraint. Marketing a product as a smoking- or nicotine-cessation aid can convert it from a food/supplement into a **regulated therapeutic product** in every market DESIRE might sell in. See **Section 9.5** before writing a word of this. The commercially correct move and the legally safe move are close together here, but they are not the same move, and the difference is specific wording.

5. Competitive landscape, pricing and offers

All figures below were taken from brand-published pages and retailer listings, and are current as of 18 September 2026. Where a brand does not publish a dose, that is recorded as **not disclosed** — which is itself the most important column in the table.

5.1 Live caffeine / energy pouch brands, with DESIRE added

Brand	Caffeine	Other disclosed actives	Undisclosed actives	Pouches/tin	Price per tin	Price per pouch	Flavours	All doses disclosed
DESIRE	80 mg	L-theanine 80 mg, L-tyrosine 40 mg, B6, B12	none	15	TBD	TBD	3 (Cool Mint, Watermelon Ice, Mixed Berry)	Yes
Roon	80 mg	L-theanine 60 mg, methylxanthine (Dynamine) 25 mg, theacrine (TeaCrine) 5 mg	none	15	\$15.00 one-time / \$9.16 subscribed	\$1.00 / \$0.61	1 (Cool Mint)	Yes

Brand	Caffeine	Other disclosed actives	Undisclosed actives	Pouches/tin	Price per tin	Price per pouch	Flavours	All doses disclosed
Ultra	0 — uses paraxanthine (enfinity), reported 100 mg , up from 75 mg Jan 2026	none published	paraxanthine, Alpha GPC, L-theanine, ginseng, B6, B12	15	\$16.00 one-time (3-can \$48) / ≈\$10.40 sub	≈\$1.07 / ≈\$0.69	5+	No
Mojo	50 mg (green tea); 100 mg line added	none published	L-theanine, N-acetyl-L-tyrosine, ginseng, yerba mate, eleuthero, rhodiola, B vitamins	15	≈\$5.50 (5-pack \$27.50)	≈\$0.37 (50 mg) / ≈\$0.60 (100 mg)	4+	No
Wip	100 mg or 200 mg (green coffee)	niacin, B6, B12, chromium (on-label)	L-theanine (listed under Other Ingredients, no amount)	15	\$7.99 single / \$7.33 (3pk) / \$6.50 (6pk)	\$0.53 / \$0.49 / \$0.43	several	Partial
Grinds coffee line	20–25 mg (2x line 50 mg)	B-vitamins; taurine in some SKUs	taurine amounts	≈18 (CHARGED line ≈12)	\$4.24–\$5.95	\$0.24–\$0.33	30+	No
Grinds energy line	80 mg	B-vitamins	amounts	15–18	\$7.98 (3-can \$23.95)	≈\$0.44–0.53	3+	No
Nectr Energy	50 mg	—	—	n/d	≈\$4.99–\$6.99	n/d	5–6	n/d
Nectr Focus	30 mg	Cognizin® citicoline 62.5 mg	—	n/d	≈\$4.99–\$6.99	n/d	3–6	n/d

Nectr figures come only from Nectr's own listicles and could not be independently verified; treat as **unconfirmed**. Grinds, Roon, Ultra, Mojo and Wip figures are from brand product pages, retailer listings or PR filings.

5.2 Where DESIRE actually sits — three real advantages and one real problem

Advantage 1 — the highest disclosed L-theanine dose in the category. Roon publishes 60 mg. Ultra, Mojo and Wip do not publish an amount at all. DESIRE's 80 mg is the highest *knowable* L-theanine dose available. [VERIFIED against the table above]

Advantage 2 — the most L-theanine per mg of caffeine of any brand that discloses.

DESIRE is 80:80 (1:1). Roon is 80:60 (1:0.75). Everyone else is unknown. **Important correction to the obvious claim:** the research literature does *not* use 1:1 — it uses L-theanine *above* caffeine, in ratios from 1:1.25 up to 1:2.4 (see Section 8.2). The honest, checkable statement is that DESIRE sits closer to the studied ratios than any disclosed competitor while still falling below them. Do not claim DESIRE matches the research. Claim it carries more L-theanine per milligram of caffeine than anything else a buyer can verify, which is true, and which no competitor can say.

Advantage 3 — full disclosure plus flavour range. Roon is the only other brand disclosing every active dose, and Roon sells **one** flavour. DESIRE sells three. Given that flavour is mentioned in 45% of reviews and energy in 1% (§3.1), **"every dose disclosed, in three flavours" is a position only DESIRE can currently occupy.**

The problem — duration. Roon's entire argument is that 6–8 hours beats 1–2 hours, and it converts that into a cost-per-hour claim where a \$0.61 pouch beats a \$0.43 pouch. DESIRE has no extended-release compound (no theacrine, no methylliberine) and will land in the 1–2 hour band alongside Mojo and Wip. **DESIRE cannot win the duration argument and should not enter it.** The counter-position is precision and calm, not length: *a known dose that does exactly what it says for as long as you need it, not a six-hour commitment you can't take back.* Note also Roon's own admission that its long half-life means users "should stop at least 8 hours before bed" — that is a real cost DESIRE does not carry.

5.3 Offer structures in market

Brand	Subscription discount	Free shipping	Guarantee (verbatim status)
Roon	Up to 54% off (headline "Save up to 54%"); \$15.00 → \$9.16/tin = 39% at the tier shown	"Free U.S. shipping on orders \$45+"	Refund policy page exists; terms not retrieved — verify before comparing
Ultra	3-can \$48 → 9-can \$93.60 subscribed (≈35% lower per pouch)	not retrieved	not retrieved
Grinds	Amazon Subscribe & Save 10–15%; volume tiers 6 cans \$4.99→\$4.24, 10 cans \$4.50→\$3.82	Amazon Prime	not retrieved

Brand	Subscription discount	Free shipping	Guarantee (verbatim status)
Wip	volume-based (6-pack 19% lower per pouch)	not retrieved	not retrieved

NO EVIDENCE FOUND for verbatim guarantee and return-policy wording, review counts and average ratings on brands' own sites, dispatch locations, delivery windows, and shipping countries. The brief asked for all of these; they require logged-in or checkout-stage access that was not retrievable. **This is a straightforward gap to close manually — one afternoon placing a test order with each competitor.**

5.4 The price band the market expects [VERIFIED]

This is the section with the clearest answer, and it should directly set DESIRE's price.

Anchors:

- **The nicotine pouch reference price is ~\$5.50 per can** (US average retail for ZYN, [Tobacco Insider](#)). This is the number the crossover customer has in their head.
- **The caffeine pouch band runs \$4.24 to \$16.00 per tin**, i.e. **\$0.24 to \$1.07 per pouch**.
- **Wip launched at an MSRP of \$5.99 and now sells at \$7.99** ([PR Newswire](#)) — a 33% increase, which suggests the mid-market has room above \$6.
- **The premium ceiling is \$15–16 one-time, and both brands charging it discount to \$9–10 on subscription**. Nobody is holding a double-digit price without a subscription escape hatch.

Read on price complaints. The only direct price language retrieved is faint praise, not rejection: *"For \$ almost a decent deal for 18 pouches"* ([Walmart, 21 May 2026](#)) and *"A much better replacement for tobacco and much, much cheaper"* ([Walmart](#)). "Value For Money" is tagged in 0.6% of 2,168 reviews. **Price is not this category's main objection.** Flavour is.

Recommendation. A premium DESIRE tin belongs at **\$12–\$15 one-time with subscription landing at \$8–\$10**, which sits alongside Roon and above everything else. Two conditions: the formulation disclosure must be visible enough to justify it, and the subscription discount must be real (35–40%), because both premium competitors have trained this buyer to expect one. Going below \$8 puts DESIRE in Wip's price war, where the only weapon is milligrams — and DESIRE has fewer of them.

5.5 Adjacent context: nicotine pouch brands

Zyn (Philip Morris, ≈70% US share, 794m cans 2025), On! (Altria), Velo (BAT), Rogue, and Lucy are the adjacent set. The only competitively relevant facts, beyond Section 4.1: **ZYN is the only nicotine pouch brand authorised by the FDA** ([Sherwood](#)), and the US format standard is **15 pouches per can**. Full profiles were not built — they add little that Section 4 does not already deliver.

6. Competitor messaging teardown

Gap first: the brief asked for Meta Ad Library and TikTok Creative Center data — which ad angles are running and which have been live longest. **NO EVIDENCE FOUND.** Neither ad library was accessible through the available tools. Long-running-ad data is the single best signal of what converts in this category, and it is missing from this document. It is also free and takes an hour to collect manually. **Do it before spending on creative.**

What follows is teardown of on-site messaging, which was retrievable.

6.1 Roon — the most sophisticated operator in the category

Element	What they run
Headline	"Clean, all-day focus. Zero nicotine, zero crash."
Brand line	"Your Highest Gear" / "Outperform"
CTA	"Lock in your focus"
Stated mechanism	Triple methylxanthine stack (caffeine + methyllicberine + theacrine) with L-theanine, producing a 6–8 hour window from one pouch
Lead benefits	1. Duration (6–8 hrs vs competitors' 1–2) 2. No crash, no jitters 3. Full dose disclosure
Proof	Six PubMed-linked citations on a single blog page; their own self-experimentation study ("Roon Study Update: We Tested 6 Nootropic Stacks On Ourselves"); an owned subreddit (r/NootropicsScience) and Discord
Villain	Explicitly named: "The Zyn Trap" — <i>"Nicotine pouches work for focus but trap you in addiction."</i>

Element	What they run
Offer	\$15.00 one-time → \$9.16 subscribed; "Save up to 54%"; free US shipping \$45+
Urgency	None detected — no countdowns, no scarcity

What Roon does that DESIRE should copy. They convert their weakness (highest per-pouch price) into their proof by changing the unit of measurement: **cost per hour of focus**, not cost per pouch. $\$0.61 \div 7 \text{ hours} = \$0.09/\text{hr}$, which beats Wip's $\$0.43 \div 1.5 \text{ hours} = \$0.29/\text{hr}$. It is a legitimate reframe and it is why they can charge double.

Where Roon is exposed. One flavour. A stated requirement to stop 8 hours before bed. And a citation practice that is impressive on the surface and thin underneath — the esports study is n-small, the methylxerine pharmacokinetic finding (caffeine half-life extended from 7.2 to 15 hours) is presented as a benefit when it is equally a description of a compound that keeps you up.

6.2 The rest of the field

Brand	Position	Mechanism claimed	Lead proof	Exposure
Grinds	"Brew-Free Coffee Alternative"; "PROUDLY MADE IN THE USA"	Real coffee grounds, buccal absorption	Founder story — two college baseball players, 2009, <i>Shark Tank</i> 2014; 15+ years trading; 2,168 reviews at 4.7	20–100 mg caffeine variance across SKUs; grounds escaping the pouch
Ultra	"Most searched"; VC-backed	Paraxanthine (enfinity) — skip the metabolic middleman	\$11m Series A , Jan 2026	Publishes no milligram amounts at all ; FAQ admits 1–2 hr window needing 3–4 pouches/day

Brand	Position	Mechanism claimed	Lead proof	Exposure
Wip	Cheapest, strongest	Green coffee caffeine, up to 200 mg	PR framing: "the \$120B caffeine industry"	200 mg dose flagged by NBC News as a youth concern; L-theanine listed with no amount
Mojo	Adaptogens + mushrooms	Green tea caffeine + rhodiola/ginseng/eleuthero	Retail distribution	Adaptogen doses undisclosed and almost certainly sub-clinical
Nectr	"Widest retail footprint"	Cognizin® citicoline	2,500+ Walmart locations	Self-published rankings; low caffeine (30–50 mg)

6.3 Saturated angles — do not run these

1. **"No crash, no jitters."** Every brand. Meaningless now.
2. **"Zero nicotine, zero sugar, zero tobacco."** Table stakes, not a position.
3. **Milligram maximalism.** Wip owns 200 mg and will always out-dose DESIRE.
4. **Nootropic ingredient-stacking.** Roon, Ultra and Mojo are in an arms race of exotic compounds. DESIRE's four actives are modest by that standard and will lose a spec-sheet fight.
5. **Self-published "best of 2026" listicles.** Five brands are doing this. The tactic is saturated and, worse, it is the thing making the category untrustworthy (§0.2).

6.4 Unused angles — the openings

Five positions nobody in the retrieved competitive set currently occupies.

1. **Honest brokerage — the trust play.** Every buyer is being lied to by five brands pretending to be reviewers. A DESIRE comparison page that **recommends a competitor for specific use cases** ("want 200 mg? buy Wip. want eight hours? buy Roon. want the

cheapest? buy Grinds.") would be the only credible voice in the category. This is uncomfortable and it is the strongest available move.

2. The ratio, not the stack. While competitors add compounds, DESIRE can subtract the argument: **80:80, the ratio the research actually used.** One number a buyer can verify in thirty seconds. See Section 8.2 for what the evidence does and does not support.

3. "One pouch, one Red Bull, no can." Nobody is using the exact 80 mg = 8.4 oz Red Bull equivalence. It is verifiable, instantly graspable, and it does the dose-education job that §3.2 objections #6 and #7 require.

4. Flavour as the primary axis. Flavour is 45% of review mentions and 1% is energy (§3.1) — and the entire category leads with pharmacology. DESIRE has three flavours against Roon's one. **Lead with the thing they actually judge you on.**

5. "We tell you everything that's in it." Only Roon and DESIRE disclose every active dose. Ultra publishes nothing. Mojo hides its adaptogens. Wip buries L-theanine under Other Ingredients. One reviewer already asked for this out loud: *"I do wish though that those ingredients would be listed on the website, especially when Taurine is one of them"* ([Walmart](#)). Transparency is not a virtue signal here — it is an unmet, stated customer request in a category built on proprietary blends (Section 7.3).

7. Horror stories and the villain

Everything in this section is documented, sourced and linked. It is also the section most likely to get DESIRE into trouble if used carelessly — see the warning at 7.5.

7.1 Panera Charged Lemonade — the defining case [VERIFIED]

This is the strongest villain evidence available to any brand in this category, because the product's failure was **not the dose. It was the disclosure.**

The product. A 30 oz Charged Lemonade with no ice contained **390 mg of caffeine** plus guarana extract and, in the large size, the equivalent of almost 30 teaspoons of sugar. Court filings noted it contained more caffeine than a Red Bull and a Monster combined ([NBC News, Oct 2023](#)).

How it was described. Panera's own website said it contained *"about as much CAFFEINE as our Dark Roast Coffee"* ([The Daily Pennsylvanian](#)). Court documents stated it was advertised as a "clean" drink. It was dispensed **self-serve, side by side with the non-caffeinated lemonades** ([case timeline](#)).

The people.

Name	Age	Circumstance	Outcome
Sarah Katz	21	UPenn student with long QT syndrome type 1; avoided energy drinks on doctors' advice	Cardiac arrest hours after drinking one, 10 Sep 2022; died
Dennis Brown	46	Florida; chromosomal disorder, high blood pressure; typically avoided energy drinks	Drank three on 9 Oct 2023; fatal cardiac arrest
Lauren Skeritt	28	Occupational therapist, Rhode Island	Permanent cardiac injuries
Luke Adams	18	Monroeville, PA	Cardiac arrest in a cinema, 9 Mar 2024

What happened next. October 2023: first suit filed; FDA said it was *"gathering information"*; Panera moved the drink behind the counter and added disclosures. **May 2024: discontinued nationwide.** October 2024: Katz case settled days before trial. **July 2025: all remaining suits settled, dismissed with prejudice.** Panera denies liability. ([NPR](#), [PEOPLE/Yahoo](#), [Washington Post](#))

One expert line that names the mechanism precisely: food safety professor Darin Detwiler observed that calling a drink *"charged"* may not be a strong enough indicator that it is a highly-caffeinated beverage ([Northeastern](#)).

Sarah Katz was careful. She had a diagnosed condition, she avoided energy drinks on medical advice, and she bought what was presented as lemonade. She did everything right. **The information failed her, not her judgement.** That is the villain, stated exactly.

7.2 Proprietary blends — peer-reviewed, and worse than most people assume [VERIFIED]

A published analysis of the **top 100 commercially available pre-workout supplements** ([Jagim et al., Nutrients 2019](#)) found:

- Mean **18.4 ± 9.7 ingredients** per product.
- **8.1 ± 9.9 of those ingredients sat inside a proprietary blend at undisclosed quantities.**

- **44.3% of all ingredients** across the sample were in proprietary blends with undisclosed amounts.
- Caffeine appeared in 86% of products at **254.0 ± 79.5 mg**.
- Beta-alanine appeared in 87% at an average dose **below the recommended efficacious level** — enough to cause the itching, not necessarily enough to work.
- The authors note *"a high degree of variation between the caffeine dose presented on the label and the actual caffeine content."*

On the regulatory mechanism: the FDA requires only that the **total weight** of a proprietary blend be listed, in descending order of predominance — not the amount of each ingredient ([same paper](#)). The authors state the consequence plainly: consumers cannot determine whether an effective dose is present, or whether stacking products puts them at risk.

This directly validates the lifter quoted in §1.1 — *"there's no instructions, I didn't even know what it is"* — as an accurate description of the market, not a careless consumer.

7.3 Energy drink dosing [VERIFIED]

- **Anais Fournier, 14**, died in December 2011 of *"cardiac arrhythmia due to caffeine toxicity"* after drinking two 24 oz Monster cans containing 240 mg each ([Wikipedia/Monster Energy](#)). [VERIFIED as reported; 2011 — **OLD**]
- **Three mainstream drinks deliver 300 mg in a single can** (Bang, Celsius Heat, Rockstar Xduration) — above EFSA's 200 mg single-dose guidance and 75% of the 400 mg daily ceiling ([source](#)).
- Germany's federal risk institute (BfR) states plainly that **three energy drink cans (240 mg) consumed in a short period already exceeds the safe single dose** ([BfR](#)).

7.4 Is there a credible case that an outside force created this problem?

The brief asked whether the beverage industry moved caffeine from a known, visible dose into large-format drinks with undisclosed blends. **Partially yes, and the defensible version is narrower than the tempting version.**

What the evidence supports [VERIFIED]:

1. **Undisclosed blends are legally permitted and near-universal.** 44.3% of ingredients in the top 100 pre-workouts are in proprietary blends. This is not a conspiracy; it is a disclosure rule that permits it.

2. **Caffeine dose scaled far past the coffee reference point.** Coffee is $\approx 80\text{--}100$ mg per 8 oz. Mainstream cans now reach 300 mg; a single Wip pouch reaches 200 mg.
3. **Products were described using the coffee reference while delivering energy-drink doses.** Panera's "about as much caffeine as our Dark Roast Coffee" on a 390 mg beverage is the documented instance.
4. **The regulatory response has been to require disclosure, not to lower doses** — see Section 9.

What the evidence does NOT support, and must not be claimed: that the industry knowingly hid caffeine to create dependence; that energy drinks are uniquely dangerous versus equivalent caffeine from coffee (EFSA found caffeine is unlikely to interact adversely with taurine or glucuronolactone at commercial concentrations); or any general claim that these products "cause" cardiac events in healthy adults. Every documented death above involved a pre-existing condition or extreme consumption. **Say that out loud in the copy.** It is more credible, not less.

7.5 The warning

DESIRE sells 80 mg of caffeine. Every villain argument above is an argument about **dose and disclosure**, and DESIRE wins both on the facts. But the moment the copy implies caffeine itself is dangerous, DESIRE is attacking its own active ingredient, and a reader can do the arithmetic: five pouches is 400 mg.

The villain is not caffeine. It is not even energy drinks. The villain is not knowing. Hold that line and every piece of evidence in this section works for DESIRE. Cross it and the same evidence works against DESIRE.

Also: naming Panera, Monster, Bang or Celsius directly in advertising invites legal attention and platform rejection. **Use the mechanism, not the brand name.** "A drink that says it has about as much caffeine as coffee, and has four times that" is the same argument with none of the exposure.

8. Curiosity and origin angles

Each item below states plainly how strong the evidence is. Two of DESIRE's four actives are well supported at DESIRE's doses. **One is not, and that is stated openly in 8.3.**

8.1 Military caffeine gum — the best hook in the category, and nobody is using it [VERIFIED, STRONG]

The US Army spent six years at the **Walter Reed Army Institute of Research** developing a non-drink caffeine format. The product was "**Stay Alert**" — five pieces of cinnamon gum per pack, **100 mg of caffeine per piece**, issued through military supply channels and later adopted into **First Strike Rations** ([DVIDS, US Army, 31 Jan 2006](#); [Government Executive, 2006](#)).

Why a non-drink format was chosen. Three stated reasons: soldiers on 72-hour operations could not stop to brew; capsules were too slow; and the gum was lightweight, compact and transportable. The absorption claim is properly sourced — a randomised trial at Walter Reed found **time to peak caffeine concentration was significantly shorter with caffeinated gum than with capsules** (Kamimori et al., *International Journal of Pharmaceutics*, 2002).

The findings. Across three studies using Stay Alert, soldiers' alertness, marksmanship (simulated and live fire), vigilance on observation and reconnaissance tasks, and physical performance during simulated operations were *maintained or improved* versus placebo gum ([Government Executive](#)).

The quote worth building a campaign on, from Dr Tom Balkin, the Walter Reed sleep researcher:

"Our studies with caffeine have shown that at the right dose it's just as effective as some other stimulants that are more powerful, like amphetamines. The advantage of caffeine is that it's widely available, doesn't require a prescription, and people have a lot of experience with it, so everybody already knows if they are sensitive to it or not." — [DVIDS, US Army, 31 Jan 2006](#)

"*At the right dose*" is the whole DESIRE argument, said by an Army researcher two decades ago. **Strength of evidence: strong.** Government-published, multiple independent sources, peer-reviewed pharmacokinetics. **Nobody in the competitive set is using this.**

One caution: this supports the *format*, not DESIRE specifically. Gum and pouches both use oral absorption, but they are not the same delivery system, and **no comparable pharmacokinetic study of caffeine pouches was found**. Do not claim Walter Reed's absorption data applies to DESIRE's pouch. Say the format has a military research lineage; do not borrow its numbers.

8.2 Caffeine + L-theanine [VERIFIED, MODERATE-TO-STRONG — but read the ratio note]

This is one of the most replicated findings in the cognitive-supplement literature. The studies, with actual doses:

Study	L-theanine	Caffeine	Ratio (caf:thea)	Finding
Owen et al., <i>Nutritional Neuroscience</i> , 2008 (n=27)	100 mg	50 mg	1:2	Improved attention-switching speed and accuracy at 60 min; reduced distractibility in a memory task
Haskell et al., 2008	250 mg	150 mg	1:1.67	Improved cognitive performance; relaxation without drowsiness
Giesbrecht et al., 2010	97 mg	40 mg	1:2.4	Improved task-switching accuracy, raised self-reported alertness, reduced tiredness
Kahathuduwa et al., <i>British Journal of Nutrition</i> (n=37, sleep-deprived)	200 mg	160 mg	1:1.25	Improved hit rate and target-distractor discrimination on a traffic-scene task; faster reaction time than placebo; increased P3b ERP amplitude

Sources: [Owen 2008](#), [2010 replication](#), [Kahathuduwa, BJN](#), [review](#).

What the evidence supports: the *combination* outperforms either alone on attention tasks. In Owen et al., **L-theanine alone had no effect**, and caffeine alone improved discriminability but not hit rate. The combination did both. The effect is on **attention-switching, accuracy and distractibility** — not on raw energy or endurance.

The ratio problem, stated honestly. Every study above uses **more L-theanine than caffeine**, between 1.25x and 2.4x. **DESIRE's 80:80 is 1:1 — below the lowest studied ratio.** DESIRE cannot claim to replicate these studies. What DESIRE *can* say, truthfully: it carries

more L-theanine per milligram of caffeine than any competitor that publishes its doses, and it is nearer the studied range than any of them.

Product recommendation, not copy: raising L-theanine to 100–120 mg would put DESIRE inside the studied range and would convert a hedged claim into a clean one. That is a formulation decision worth costing.

8.3 L-tyrosine [VERIFIED, WEAK AT DESIRE'S DOSE — do not build copy on this]

L-tyrosine is genuinely studied for cognitive performance under **acute stressors** — cold, noise, and sleep deprivation specifically — rather than for everyday alertness. That much is real.

The dose problem is severe. Clinical L-tyrosine research typically doses in **grams** (commonly 100–150 mg per kg of bodyweight, i.e. 7–10 g for a 70 kg adult). A published nootropic-combination trial used **300 mg** ([ClinicalTrials.gov NCT02857829](https://clinicaltrials.gov/ct2/show/study/NCT02857829)). The top 100 pre-workouts average **348 mg** ([Jagim et al.](#)).

DESIRE contains 40 mg. That is roughly one-eighth of a typical pre-workout dose and orders of magnitude below clinical dosing. Additionally, one review notes that L-theanine or L-tyrosine taken before a stressor **did not affect markers of stress** ([ADDF review](#)).

Directive: do not make any performance, focus or stress claim attributable to L-tyrosine. List it on the label as an ingredient. Do not put it in a headline, a benefit bullet, or a mechanism diagram. If DESIRE builds a "clinically informed formulation" story around a 40 mg tyrosine dose, the brand is doing the exact thing Section 7 attacks competitors for — fairy-dusting — and a single informed critic can prove it in one search. **This is the largest self-inflicted risk in DESIRE's current positioning.**

8.4 The pouch format's actual origin [VERIFIED]

A cleaner story than the market assumes, and it undercuts the "riding the Zyn wave" objection (§4.4).

- The first nicotine pouch product was developed in the early 2000s by a small Swedish startup, **Niconovum**, and registered in **2008 as Zonnic — a medicinal nicotine replacement product at 2 mg**. RJ Reynolds bought Niconovum in 2009. ([Wikipedia: Nicotine pouch](#))
- **ZYN was introduced in 2016** by Swedish Match ([Wikipedia: Zyn](#)).

- **Grinds — the first caffeine pouch — was invented in 2009** by two college baseball players trying to help teammates quit chewing tobacco, seven years *before* ZYN existed. *Shark Tank* appearance 2014. ([Grinds history](#); [getgrinds.com](#))

The hook: the pouch format was invented as a *medicine* (a 2 mg NRT product), and the caffeine pouch predates ZYN by seven years. The oral pouch was never a nicotine delivery device first — it was a way to *get off* nicotine, and the tobacco industry adopted it afterwards. [VERIFIED] That is a genuinely surprising, defensible origin story and it answers the sceptic directly.

8.5 Historical non-drink caffeine formats

PARTIAL EVIDENCE. Confirmed: Stay Alert gum (1990s–2006, Walter Reed), Jolt Cola energy gum, Wrigley's **Alert** gum (2013), and Neuro gum ([Wikipedia](#)). The functional chewing gum market was valued at **\$2.17 billion in 2024**, projected to \$3.76 billion by 2030 (Grand View Research, cited [here](#)).

NO EVIDENCE FOUND for the deeper history the brief asked about — the origins of caffeine tablets and chewables. Not retrievable.

9. Regulatory limits on what DESIRE can claim

This is research, not legal advice. Every item marked △ requires a qualified food-law solicitor in that jurisdiction before anything is published or printed. The single most important finding in this section is 9.1, and it affects DESIRE's Canadian packaging directly.

9.1 Canada — the 56 mg threshold, and why it matters urgently [VERIFIED]

Canada regulates products like this under the **Supplemented Foods Regulations**. **As of 1 January 2026, all supplemented foods must carry the new labelling:** a *Supplemented Food Facts* table (not a Nutrition Facts table), a "Supplemented with" section listing each supplemental ingredient and its amount, and where required a **caution identifier** on the front of pack — an exclamation mark with the words "Supplemented" and "Health Canada" ([Health Canada](#)).

The threshold that catches DESIRE:

Caffeine per serving, solid supplemented food	Required
Up to 56 mg	"Contains caffeine" on the principal display panel
More than 56 mg	"High caffeine content" on the label, plus the cautionary statement "Do not [eat/drink] on the same day as any other source of caffeine" (in force since 25 Nov 2025)

Sources: [Health Canada guidance](#), [Health Canada caffeine proposal](#), [regulatory summary](#).

DESIRE is 80 mg per pouch. That is over the threshold. If DESIRE is regulated as a solid supplemented food in Canada, the tin must carry "High caffeine content" and a statement telling the buyer **not to consume any other caffeine that day**. For a product marketed to people who also drink coffee, that is a commercially significant constraint on both the pack design and the copy — and it is not optional.

Health Canada's intake guidance ([source](#)): adults 18+ **400 mg/day**; planning pregnancy, pregnant or breastfeeding **300 mg/day**; children and adolescents up to 18 **2.5 mg per kg bodyweight**. Acute limit generally **200 mg per serving**.

⚠ **Unresolved and urgent:** whether an oral pouch that is *not swallowed* fits any category on Health Canada's **List of Permitted Supplemented Food Categories** at all. If it does not, DESIRE may not be lawfully sellable in Canada as a supplemented food without a pre-market submission. **This is the first question to put to a regulatory consultant.**

9.2 European Union — there is no authorised health claim for caffeine [VERIFIED]

This is the finding that surprises most brands, and it is unambiguous.

Under Regulation (EC) No 1924/2006, claims about caffeine's physiological effects are **health claims** and must be authorised before use. EFSA gave **positive opinions** on caffeine claims — including that a product should contain **at least 75 mg per serving** to bear an alertness claim. The European Commission proposed authorising them. **The European Parliament vetoed the authorisation in 2016**, on the grounds that permitting alertness claims would encourage energy drink consumption among adolescents ([European Parliament veto](#); [peer-reviewed analysis](#); [Commission Regulation \(EU\) 2016/1411](#)).

The result: four applications on increased alertness, attention and endurance received positive EFSA opinions and were **never authorised**. There is currently **no authorised health claim for caffeine in the EU** ([analysis](#)).

What this means in practice for DESIRE in the EU:

- ✗ Cannot say caffeine helps increase **alertness**.
- ✗ Cannot say caffeine helps improve **concentration, attention** or **endurance**.
- ✗ Under CJEU Case C-363/19, a vague slogan ("good for focus") does **not** escape this — general references to wellbeing must be linked to a specific *authorised* claim.
- ⚠ Note the bitter irony: DESIRE's 80 mg **exceeds EFSA's own 75 mg substantiation threshold**. The science was accepted. The claim was still vetoed. Being right is not a defence.

The workaround is B6 and B12. Vitamin claims *are* on the authorised list under Regulation 432/2012 — typically covering contribution to normal energy-yielding metabolism, reduction of tiredness and fatigue, and normal psychological function. ⚠ **The exact permitted wording and the minimum "significant amount" per serving must be confirmed against the current EU Register before use.** If DESIRE's B6 and B12 doses hit the significant-amount threshold, the vitamins — not the caffeine — are what legally carries an energy message in Europe. That is a formulation-and-legal question worth answering precisely, because it determines whether DESIRE can say anything at all in the EU.

9.3 United Kingdom

The UK retained EU-derived food law post-Brexit, including Regulation 1924/2006 on claims and Regulation 1169/2011 on labelling — note that the rejected-claims regulation is hosted on [legislation.gov.uk](#) as retained law ([source](#)). ⚠ **Assume the EU position in 9.2 applies in the UK unless a solicitor confirms divergence.**

⚠ **Requires verification:** Regulation 1169/2011 Annex III sets mandatory caffeine warnings for foods and beverages with added caffeine, generally along the lines of "*High caffeine content. Not recommended for children or pregnant or breast-feeding women*" plus the caffeine content. **The exact wording and whether a non-swallowed oral pouch falls within scope was not verified in this research and must be checked.**

9.4 United States [PARTIAL]

Likely regulated as a **dietary supplement** under DSHEA rather than as a conventional food. Verified points:

- Under **21 CFR § 101.36**, the Supplement Facts panel must disclose the **per-serving amount of caffeine**, including caffeine contributed by herbal sources such as guarana or green tea extract. Hiding caffeine inside a proprietary blend without stating the total per-serving amount **can be cited as misbranding under FD&C Act § 343** ([food-law analysis](#)).
- The GRAS listing at 21 CFR § 182.1180 covers cola-type beverages and **does not** justify high-caffeine supplement servings ([same source](#)).
- FDA cites **400 mg/day** as the level not generally associated with negative effects in healthy adults.
- Structure/function claims are permitted with the standard disclaimer; disease claims are not. Roon carries the standard disclaimer on every page.

NO EVIDENCE FOUND for US enforcement actions or recalls specifically against caffeine pouch brands.

9.5 Age restrictions, minors, and the cessation trap — two live risks

Risk 1 — minors. [VERIFIED] **NBC News has reported on caffeine pouches and teenagers**, specifically flagging Wip's 200 mg dose as a concern for younger users ([reported via Roon's citation](#)). Teen nicotine pouch use rose from 3.0% to 5.4% in a year ([Northeastern](#)). Both EFSA and Health Canada set adolescent limits by bodyweight (**3 mg/kg** and **2.5 mg/kg** respectively) — for a 60 kg teenager, roughly 150–180 mg, or two DESIRE pouches.

The category already carries press scrutiny about youth appeal, and **DESIRE's flavour range — Watermelon Ice and Mixed Berry — is precisely the characteristic that drew regulatory attention to flavoured nicotine products**. This is not a reason to change the flavours. It is a reason to put an age gate on the site, state 18+ on the tin, and keep creative away from anything that reads as school, campus or teen-coded. ⚠ Age restrictions vary by jurisdiction and were not fully mapped here.

Risk 2 — the cessation trap, and this is the serious one. Section 4 shows DESIRE's strongest position is the nicotine crossover. But **marketing a product as an aid to quitting smoking or nicotine can reclassify it as a therapeutic product** — a drug in the US, a Natural Health Product or drug in Canada, a medicine in the UK and EU — with an entirely different and far more onerous approval regime. Recall from Section 8.4 that the original pouch, Zonnica, was **registered as a medicinal NRT product**. That precedent cuts directly against DESIRE.

The distinction is the wording, and it is narrow:

- ❌ "Quit Zyn with DESIRE." ❌ "Helps you stop using nicotine." ❌ "Nicotine replacement." ❌ "Cessation aid."
- ✅ "Nicotine free." ✅ "The same format, without the nicotine." ✅ Customer testimonials in customers' own words, clearly attributed.
- ⚠️ Even republishing a customer's unsolicited review saying it helped them quit **may constitute a claim by the brand** in some jurisdictions. Grinds does this freely; Grinds may simply not have been challenged.

Get this specific question in front of a lawyer before the crossover positioning goes live. It is the difference between DESIRE's best market and a regulatory action.

9.6 What needs a lawyer, in priority order

1. Does an oral pouch fit a permitted Canadian supplemented food category at all? **(blocks Canadian sale)**
2. Exact Canadian cautionary statements required at 80 mg per pouch, and how they sit on the tin. **(blocks Canadian packaging)**
3. How far testimonial-based nicotine-crossover marketing can go in each market before it is a therapeutic claim. **(blocks the best positioning)**
4. Whether DESIRE's B6/B12 doses meet the EU/UK significant-amount threshold to carry an authorised claim. **(determines whether DESIRE can say anything in Europe)**
5. Exact UK/EU Annex III caffeine warning wording and whether a non-swallowed pouch is in scope.
6. Age-gating obligations per market.

10. Copy deliverables

A. Language bank — 65 verbatim phrases, by theme

Exact words only. Nothing cleaned up. Sources in Sections 1–4 and the appendix.

The crash and the comedown

1. "anything that jacks you up for a while makes you pay for it later"
2. "Didn't seem to have a crash effect like some do"
3. "no crash out and definitely no itching"
4. "wrestling to get to sleep after the sun comes up"
5. "I know some people who can't sleep at all if it daylight out"

The jitters and the overshoot 6. "ants biting me all over my body for hours" 7. "full body fire ant biting itchiness" 8. "95% of them give me the jitters and for many uncomfortable hours after I've finished working out" 9. "ended up in the hospital with heart palpitations" 10. "it doesn't give me the jitters, but it provides just the right amount of energy" 11. "made quite a few trips to the bathroom" 12. "they are very dangerous a lot end up as being amphetamine analogs"

Not knowing the dose — the richest vein 13. "there's no instructions, I didn't even know what it is" 14. "They should put warnings on those things! Big warnings!" 15. "it is easy to overdo it, if you ignore the warning signs" 16. "I do wish though that those ingredients would be listed on the website" 17. "I wasn't focused like some products claim"

Dependence — how they moralise it 18. "He was addicted to caffeine, and needed it just to function at a near normal level" 19. "In short, he was a drug addict" 20. "It is not good to be dependent on sugar and caffeine to stay awake" 21. "Most of us with common sense are wary of over the counter supplements" 22. "I can't stop drinking sodas" 23. "a 6pk or more a day of soda has gotten out of hand"

The moment of need 24. "Gives me the extra boost at the end of the day to make it through work" 25. "keep me awake over the night shift" 26. "She uses Grinds when driving her route" 27. "it forces drivers to drive tired so they drink that stuff to get thru the day" 28. "Craving peach" 29. "they replace my snacking"

Cynicism about the category 30. "Don't buy pre-workouts... They're a waste of money just drink coffee" 31. "Any actual effects or just capitalizing on the Zyn craze" 32. "I dropped a pretty penny trying them myself" 33. "Not sure about an energy boost but maybe"

Flavour — 45% of all review mentions 34. "The flavor starts good but after a short while it tends to get bitter, but it works" 35. "The taste is decent at first, but it turns kind of sour" 36. "the taste of the caffeine starts to overcome the flavoring after a while" 37. "Terrible taste and texture. Almost made me throw up" 38. "the initial flavor the first few minutes is so overpowering it gave me headache" 39. "the smell of the container made me nauseous" 40. "They do have a bitterness to them but most caffeine pouches do" 41. "Only wish the flavor would last longer" 42. "tastes amazing easy to use and long lasting flavor" 43. "Slightly dry but once it gets going it has great flavor" 44. "Very strong. Hard to keep in my mouth for more than a few minutes"

Build quality — competitor weakness 45. "These don't dissolve to nothing, each pouch is filled" 46. "never had any empty/half full pouches like with other brands" 47. "too dry, covered with coffee grounds, popping open and leaking" 48. "The pouch durability is what

actually needed to be fixed" 49. "I'm a weirdo tho and think they are to wet" 50. "Would like them a tad larger"

Discretion, and discretion failing 51. "Copenhagen mouth, especially in the office or when hanging out with family" 52. "I didn't even realize that the grinds pouch was still in my mouth" 53. "I had to spit out the first few minutes of liquid because it was to overpowering to swallow" 54. "spit or swallow when 'dipping' one of these?"

The nicotine crossover 55. "its like candy in your mouth" 56. "Trying to stay away from nicotine and saw these" 57. "im trying to quit smoking. So i have been trying all kinds of different stuff" 58. "Great alternative and love these" 59. "mimicking the 'process' of using it" 60. "I'm getting closer to quitting the zyn!" 61. "these take the edge off better than other brands" 62. "These are not like the real thing, that being said they are great!" 63. "It's as close as you will get" 64. "A much better replacement for tobacco and much, much cheaper" 65. "For \$ almost a decent deal for 18 pouches"

B. Hook bank — 32 openers, each traceable to evidence

From the dose-disclosure evidence (§7.2)

1. "The average pre-workout contains 18 ingredients. Eight of them don't have to tell you how much." — *Jagim et al., top-100 analysis. All segments.*
2. "44% of the ingredients in your pre-workout are in a blend the label doesn't have to measure." — *same. Gym.*
3. "'There's no instructions, I didn't even know what it is.' He'd just drunk a whole can." — *Steam, 2024. Gym.*
4. "One pouch. 80 mg. That's the whole label." — *product fact. All.*
5. "Everything in this tin is on the tin. All of it. In milligrams." — *§5.1 disclosure gap. All.*

From Panera (§7.1) — mechanism, never the brand name 6. "It was sold next to the lemonade. It had more caffeine than a Red Bull and a Monster combined." — *Professionals, students.* 7. "The label said it had about as much caffeine as dark roast coffee. It had 390 milligrams." — *All.* 8. "She had a heart condition. She avoided energy drinks. She ordered a lemonade." — *All. Handle with care.* 9. "Calling a drink 'charged' is not a dose." — *Detwiler, Northeastern. All.*

From the Red Bull equivalence (§2.1) 10. "One pouch = one Red Bull. Minus the can, the sugar and the 12 minutes." — *All.* 11. "80 mg is 80 mg whether it comes in a 250 ml can or something the size of a stick of gum." — *All.* 12. "Three of the biggest energy drinks put

300 mg in one can. Europe's food safety regulator says 200 is the single-dose limit." — *EFSA + caffeine tables. Professionals, gym.*

From Walter Reed (§8.1) — strongest unused angle 13. "The US Army spent six years figuring out how to give soldiers caffeine without a cup." — *All*. 14. "'At the right dose it's just as effective as some other stimulants that are more powerful, like amphetamines.' — Walter Reed Army Institute of Research." — *Gym, professionals*. 15. "You can't brew coffee on hour 60 of an operation. That's why they put it in your mouth instead." — *Drivers, shift workers*. 16. "Issued in First Strike Rations. 100 mg a piece." — *Gym, drivers*.

From the nicotine crossover (§4) 17. "Fifteen pouches. Same tin. No nicotine." — *PMI's own 15-per-can US standard. Crossover*. 18. "You didn't miss the nicotine. You missed the tin." — *ritual evidence, §4.3. Crossover*. 19. "'Trying to stay away from nicotine and saw these.' — verified buyer, May 2026." — *Crossover*. 20. "The pouch wasn't invented for nicotine. It was invented to get people off it — as a 2 mg medicine, in Sweden, before Zyn existed." — *§8.4. Crossover, sceptics*. 21. "The first caffeine pouch was made in 2009 by two college baseball players. Zyn launched in 2016." — *§8.4. Answers "just capitalizing on the Zyn craze"*. 22. "Keep the habit. Drop the dependency." — *△ check against §9.5 before use*.

From the flavour evidence (§3.1) 23. "We read 2,168 reviews of caffeine pouches. Flavour was mentioned 981 times. Energy was mentioned 21." — *All. This is a genuinely startling stat*. 24. "Most caffeine pouches taste fine for four minutes." — *objection #1. All*. 25. "'The taste of the caffeine starts to overcome the flavoring after a while.' We fixed that part first." — *△ only if true*. 26. "Three flavours. The market leader in this stack sells one." — *Roon. All*.

From dependence attitudes (§1.4) 27. "Needing it isn't the problem. Not knowing how much you took is." — *Professionals, drivers*. 28. "A measured dose you chose beats a 32 oz can the truck stop had." — *Drivers*. 29. "You're not tired because you're weak. You're tired because your shift ends at 4 a.m." — *Shift workers*.

From the trust vacuum (§0.2, §6.4) 30. "Every 'best caffeine pouch of 2026' list on page one of Google was written by a caffeine pouch company." — *verified. All*. 31. "Here's when you shouldn't buy ours." — *the honest-broker play, §6.4*. 32. "We'll tell you the milligrams. Ask the other four." — *§5.1. All*.

C. Objection and answer table

Objection	Strongest honest answer	Proof or product fact needed
Flavour turns bitter	Name it before they hit it; state how long DESIRE's flavour actually holds	Timed in-house testing. Do not publish a number you have not measured.
Caffeine taste bleeds through	Explain the flavour system, and don't overclaim	Formulation detail; blind taste panel
Overpowering in the first minutes	Give a usage instruction: where to place it, what the first 60 seconds feel like	On-pack and on-page usage guidance
"Do I swallow the liquid?"	Answer it plainly, above the fold, in the FAQ and on the tin	A clear, unembarrassed one-line instruction
"Didn't feel the kick"	Set the expectation: 80 mg is one Red Bull, not a 300 mg pre-workout. Buccal onset feels different from a drink	Red Bull equivalence [VERIFIED]; onset timing needs measuring
"Not sure it did anything"	Tell them what 80 mg does and does not do	Honest expectation-setting copy
Dose inconsistency across flavours	DESIRE is 80 mg in all three. Competitors vary 20-100 mg	[VERIFIED — §5.1]
Pouches underfilled / falling apart	Show fill weight and construction	QC data, photography, batch testing
Grounds escaping / "Copenhagen mouth"	DESIRE is not a coffee-grounds pouch	Product fact; visual demonstration
"Is this a nicotine product?"	Nicotine free, front of tin, first three words of every ad	Label [VERIFIED as a design decision]
"Just capitalizing on the Zyn craze"	The caffeine pouch predates Zyn by seven years; the pouch format began as a 2 mg medicine	[VERIFIED — §8.4]

Objection	Strongest honest answer	Proof or product fact needed
Fear of addiction	Caffeine dependence is real and mild; DESIRE is 80 mg, half a single-dose guidance	EFSA 200 mg single dose [VERIFIED]
Gum or teeth damage	0.2% of 2,168 reviews mention irritation. Answer in FAQ only — do not raise it on the page	[VERIFIED — §3.1]
Price per tin	Reframe to per-use vs a \$3.50 energy drink or a \$5 latte	Final pricing · §5.4
Undisclosed ingredients	Every active, in milligrams, on the tin	[VERIFIED as a real differentiator — §5.1]
Subscription lock-in	Publish cancellation terms in plain language beside the subscribe button	Cancellation flow must actually be one click
Shipping / damaged tins	Publish dispatch location and delivery windows	Operational data
"Won't it wreck my sleep?"	80 mg clears faster than a 300 mg drink; give a cut-off time	Note Roon requires an 8-hour cut-off; DESIRE's is shorter
Does it work as well as pre-workout?	No — and say so. It is 80 mg, not 350 mg. It is for the other 23 hours	Honest positioning
Is it for kids?	18+. Age gate the site	§9.5

D. Comparison table

	DESIRE	Coffee (8 oz)	Energy drink (16 oz)	Pre-workout	Caffeine pills
Caffeine	80 mg	80–100 mg	160–300 mg	150–350 mg	100–200 mg

	DESIRE	Coffee (8 oz)	Energy drink (16 oz)	Pre-workout	Caffeine pills
Other actives	L-theanine 80 mg, L-tyrosine 40 mg, B6, B12 — all disclosed	none	taurine, B vitamins, blends	≈18 ingredients, 44% in undisclosed blends	none
Sugar	0 g	0 g black	0–54 g	0 g	0 g
Calories	0	≈5	0–230	≈5–10	0
Time to consume	<1 min to place	5–15 min + brewing	15–30 min	5 min mix + 20–30 min wait	<1 min
Portable	Yes — tin in a pocket	No	Bulky, cold chain	Tub + shaker + water	Yes
Cleanup	None	Cup	Can	Shaker	None
Discreet	Yes	No	No	No	Yes
Cost per serving	TBD (\$5.4)	\$0.30 home / \$3–6 cafe	\$2.50–3.50	\$1–2	\$0.15–0.30
Dose certainty	Exact, printed, same in all 3 flavours	Varies widely by brew	Printed	Often not disclosed	Exact

E. Core belief statements, in their voice

Gym-goers. "I need the stimulant — I'm not pretending otherwise. What I don't need is three hours of feeling like I've got ants under my skin from a scoop that won't tell me what's in it. Give me the number and let me decide."

Students. NO EVIDENCE FOUND. No student quotes were retrievable. Writing a belief statement here would be invention. Survey before writing student copy.

Gamers. NO EVIDENCE FOUND. Same.

Professionals, shift workers, drivers. "Needing something to get through is a weakness, but the schedule doesn't care what I need. Coffee stopped working two jobs ago. I'd rather take a measured dose I chose than a gallon of sugar because that's what the truck stop had."

Nicotine pouch crossover. "It was never really about the nicotine — it was the tin, the lip, having something. I'm not going back, but I'm not going to pretend I don't miss it. If I can keep the part that was a habit and lose the part that was a hook, I'll take that trade."

F. The villain

The villain is not caffeine, and it is not energy drinks. It is the industry's habit of separating the dose from the label. A 30 oz beverage carrying 390 mg of caffeine and guarana was sold self-serve next to the lemonade, described on its maker's own website as containing "about as much caffeine as our Dark Roast Coffee." Sarah Katz had long QT syndrome, avoided energy drinks on her doctors' advice, and bought what she was told was lemonade. She died. Three more people sued; two of them are dead. All four cases settled. In the supplement aisle the same pattern is legal and routine: a peer-reviewed analysis of the hundred best-selling pre-workouts found 44.3% of ingredients hidden inside proprietary blends with undisclosed amounts, and the authors noted a high degree of variation between what the label claimed and what was actually in the tub. **The enemy is not the stimulant. It is being handed a dose you cannot see, in a container that tells you it's something milder.** DESIRE's entire answer is a single number printed on a tin: 80 mg, the same in all three flavours, and every other active listed in milligrams beside it.

G. Top 10 insights, ranked by likely effect on conversion

1. **Walmart files this category under Smoking Cessation.** Retail has already decided what a caffeine pouch is for. Positioning against that taxonomy is fighting the shelf. [§0.2, §4.5]
2. **Flavour is mentioned 981 times in 2,168 reviews. Energy is mentioned 21 times.** The category leads with pharmacology and is judged on taste. [§3.1]
3. **DESIRE's 15-per-tin format is an exact match to the US nicotine pouch standard,** per PMI's own SEC filing. The pack already speaks the crossover customer's language. [§4.1]
4. **One pouch = one Red Bull (80 mg).** Verifiable, instant, and nobody is using it. [§2.1]
5. **There is no authorised health claim for caffeine in the EU** — vetoed by the European Parliament despite positive EFSA opinions. Kills most European copy before it is written. [§9.2]
6. **Canada requires "High caffeine content" plus "Do not eat on the same day as any other source of caffeine" above 56 mg.** DESIRE is 80 mg. This changes the tin. [§9.1]
7. **Every top-ten search result is a competitor's sales page dressed as a review.** The honest-broker position is unoccupied and cheap to take. [§0.2, §6.4]
8. **44.3% of ingredients in the top 100 pre-workouts sit in undisclosed proprietary blends.** Peer-reviewed. This is the villain, with a citation. [§7.2]

9. **DESIRE's 40 mg L-tyrosine is roughly one-eighth of a typical pre-workout dose and far below any clinical dose.** Do not build claims on it. This is the biggest self-inflicted risk in the current positioning. [§8.3]
10. **The US Army's Walter Reed institute spent six years developing non-drink caffeine and said at the right dose it rivals amphetamines.** Free, verifiable, unused by every competitor. [§8.1]

H. Open questions — what to survey or test

Evidence gaps this research could not close:

1. **Students and gamers: zero verbatim evidence.** Two of the five named segments are entirely unevidenced. Survey them or drop them from copy.
2. **Reddit was not retrievable.** The brief's top-priority source is largely absent. Manual reading of r/Supplements, r/Nootropics, r/Zyn, r/QuittingZyn, r/Truckers and r/NursingUK would likely triple the language bank.
3. **Meta Ad Library and TikTok Creative Center were inaccessible.** Long-running-ad data is the best available signal of what converts. One hour, free.
4. **Competitor guarantees, return policies, review counts, shipping terms.** Place a test order with Roon, Wip, Mojo and Grinds.
5. **Why did caffeine pills fail?** They solve the same problem for a tenth of the price. Whatever killed them is the thing DESIRE's format must visibly fix. [§2.5]
6. **No pharmacokinetic data on caffeine pouches.** Gum has it; pouches don't. Onset and duration claims are currently unsupported for this format.
7. **Verify the Jed Rose denicotinized-cigarette papers directly** before citing the ritual research. It reached this document via a competitor's blog. [§4.3]

Product and pricing decisions raised by this research:

8. **Raise L-theanine to 100–120 mg?** Would put DESIRE inside the studied caffeine:L-theanine range and convert a hedged claim into a clean one. [§8.2]
9. **Keep 40 mg L-tyrosine at all?** It cannot carry a claim. It can carry a credibility risk.
10. **Measure flavour duration and onset in-house.** The #1 objection in the category, and DESIRE currently has no number to answer it with.
11. **Test price at \$12–15 one-time / \$8–10 subscription.** [§5.4]
12. **Test the honest-broker comparison page** against a conventional one. [§6.4]

Appendix — additional raw verbatim quotes

Quotes not used in the body. Spelling and punctuation preserved exactly.

[INCENTIVISED] marks platform-labelled incentivised reviews.

A1. Nicotine and tobacco crossover

"I've been using oral tobacco for over a decade. By alternating in this product I've been able to reduce my Tobacco usage by half in the last month." — Melissa G., 5 Jun 2018

"I have been using this product for just over a month and love it. I was able to stop chewing because of the satisfaction I receive from Grinds... I did and I have been using smokeless tobacco for over 45 years." — Gary R., 10 Apr 2019

"I used grinds to quit chewing and it really really helped. I've been snus free for 4 months... I'm a weirdo tho and think they are to wet so I leave the can open over night to dry the pouches out a tiny bit." — Abby L., 3 Jul 2020

"I started chewing tobacco at 13 and smoking at 17. Finally at 45 years old someone told me about Grinds. Of all the things that I ever tried using to quit tobacco this was/is the best. It took me about 3 months to get used to it. And now here I am almost 5 years later and still tobacco free." — Charles C., 26 Mar 2020

"I have been a smokeless tobacco user for 20+ years. Have tried to quit with many different products. I usually have a dip in for 8-10 hours a day. So far, Grinds has kept me away from tobacco for almost two weeks. Only wish the flavor would last longer." — Craig M., 5 Feb 2019

"Like these a whole heckuva lot better than the loose stuff made from kudzu. When I did use dip, I used shoal pouches so these are pretty close. Would like them a tad larger, but that being said when I get the urge for nicotine these take the edge off better than other brands." — Jason K., 22 Sep 2020

"My husband chose to try this because of my daughter and her concern for his health. Not only did he loved it! His whole family loves it too!! We can't be more thankful for this product. He hasn't had any cravings, withdrawals or relapses back to tobacco." — Renee P., 26 Sep 2020

"I learned about Grinds from a commercial where they stayed 2 ball players invented Grinds. I took my first pouch about a year ago, and have not looked back. Thank You Grinds for allowing me to keep years of my life by no longer using tobacco products." — Larry W., 6 Aug 2018

"These have done a fabulous job of curbing my cravings for over a month now. Will definitely continue using these on my journey of NO TOBACCO!" — Daniel V., 16 Aug 2016

"Highly recommend for anyone who is looking for a tobacco alternative." — Brian P., 17 Apr 2019

"Last week I was out skiing in Montana. I was sharing an elevator with a gentleman at my hotel, who was picking some chew out from in between his teeth. I asked him if he had ever tried Grinds. He asked me if it was a restaurant, I chuckled and handed him half a tin of Caramel. Fast forward to the next day his wife came up to me (never met these folks before) and literally wrapped her arms around me and said thank you so much I have been trying to get my husband to stop chewing for over 15 years" — Martin B., 8 Feb 2019

All from [Grinds New Orleans reviews, via Walmart](#).

A2. Unexpected use cases worth noting

"I love this product! I was not a tobacco user and didn't have a habit to kick. But Grinds has helped me loose weight. It was a nice surprise. I travled a lot for work and always had a snack in the car to kill time. Once I found Grinds, they replace my snacking - and I've lost weight." — Alan F., 11 Apr 2019 — **snack replacement, unprompted**

"The caffeine has been helping with the quitting of soda." — cristina, 13 Mar 2026 — **soda replacement**

"I discovered this product and it has significantly helped in 1) keep me awake, and 2) assisting with quitting real tobacco" — Peter C., 23 Jun 2018 — **dual job, night shift**

A3. Flavour and product experience

"Wow Instantly my Favorite flavor. I have found best success and ordering direct from GRINDS here on Walmart vs other sellers. They are fresh, moist, flavorful. However they have been too dry, covered with coffee grounds, popping open and leaking, %26 lacking flavor when but non direct. WHY IS THIS GRINDS?? The expiration dates are the same and within the timeframe" — KC [INCENTIVISED]

"I don't know if it has anything to do with the packaging change, but the pouch taste completely different. They are way too heavy in the coffee flavor." — James, 6 Oct 2023

"I thought the cream after taste was too over powering. Was hoping it was be more bitter and flavorful but honestly all I could taste was the cream. It got a little old (and slightly nauseating) after a while." — Trevor S., 10 Oct 2020

"Flavor wise, I'll be honest. Kind of underwhelming. Maybe because I'm used to the strong mint pouches from SMC and Oregon Mint Snuff, but I wasn't blown away with coffee flavor, or much of any flavor, really." — jimmykeeper, KillTheCan.org

"The pouches were the perfect size and I often times found myself forgetting that I had them in and would handle the duties of my job with them, including speaking to the public without anyone noticing" — Sox2012, KillTheCan.org — **the discretion promise, working**

"Grinds seem to be a love-it-or-hate-it thing." — Sox2012, same source

"I was expecting it to be like the coffee flavored zyns which to me taste delicious. This taste is very coffee tasting which I'm not a fan of as I don't drink strong coffee."
— Amazon Customer, via [review aggregation](#) — **expectation anchored to Zyn**

"Very strong. Hard to keep in my mouth for more than a few minutes. Great if you love chewing coffee grounds. The product is exactly as listed. Just too strong for my taste." — Trisha Sorensen, same source

"The caffeine punch of this product is pretty good, but the best part is that the coffee grounds come out of the pouch within 45 seconds of putting them in your mouth... only to have the experience of Copenhagen mouth, especially in the office or when hanging out with family." — Jon, Amazon, same source (sarcastic)

"Slightly dry but once it gets going it has great flavor." — DO, same source

A4. Pre-workout and stimulant experience

"You probably took something with Beta-alanine in it. Source : been there, done that."
— AerSilver, [Steam Forums](#), 24 Apr 2024

"to me it sounds like u overdosed" — same thread

"I drank the stuff at around 5:30 and started working out at 6:15. About 35 minutes into my P90X Arms & Shoulders workout I got dizzy, vision was blurred and I almost passed out. I laid on the floor with my feet up on the bed for about a half hour, then spent about 30-45 minutes on the toilet, started to get nauseous then spent another hour or so on the bathroom floor. Room spinning the entire time." — [AnandTech forums](#) [OLD]

"The salesman at GNC warned me that it'll give me a warm tingly feeling like a 5 hour energy drink. I drank it 30 minutes ago and I feel nothing, just like I felt nothing yesterday." — Jeff7181, same source [OLD]

"I've tried NO-Explode. Made me feel bloated and sometimes have to shit in the middle of the workout." — [AnandTech](#) [OLD]

"Exercise really focus on your diet it has a huge effect on my anxiety at least. Don't bully yourself ease into working back out or even a long walk." — [HealthUnlocked](#)

A5. Drivers and shift work

"you don't need an energy drink if you eat right exercise and get the correct amount of sleep" — nhroadhog01, [TheTruckersReport](#) [2010 — OLD]

"You need to spend 11 hours driving at night on desert roads where you are just about the only one out there." — [TheTruckersReport](#) [2010 — OLD]

"Really, you have 2 legal choices for a pick-me-up, as far as I see it." — [TheTruckersReport](#) [2010 — OLD]

A6. On the category itself

"These are nice, simple Caffeine pouches. Worth considering" — FeorH, [Slickdeals](#), 20 May 2025

"I am so happy with this product Others please consider it. I will buy again." — LI, 10 Sep 2026

"Great taste and energy boost" — Franklin, 16 Sep 2026 — **the most recent retrieved review in the corpus**

"Just gotta get used to it." — Kimmie, 21 May 2026 [INCENTIVISED] — **an onboarding expectation worth setting explicitly**

Sources

Every page listed was opened and read, not taken from a search snippet.

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- [Steam Forums — pre-workout thread, Apr 2024](#)
- [HealthUnlocked — C4 hospitalisation account](#)
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- [AnandTech — pre-workout threads](#)
- [TheTruckersReport — energy drinks · 5-hour Energy · non-caffeinated drivers](#)

Competitor and market data

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- [Grinds — 6-can sampler pricing · Amazon 80 mg listing](#)
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Nicotine pouch market (primary filings)

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- [Kahathuduwa et al., *British Journal of Nutrition* — high-dose combination, sleep-deprived adults](#)
- [Caffeine and L-theanine review, University of Memphis](#)
- [ADDF — L-theanine evidence review](#)
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- [Government Executive — Walter Reed trial results, 2006](#)
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Regulatory

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- [Health Canada — Caffeine in Foods, RMDI table](#)
- [Health Canada — proposal to modify caffeine as a supplemental ingredient](#)
- [Health Canada — new cautionary labels](#) · [56 mg threshold analysis](#)
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